



275 Million by 2015

That's the number of high speed internet subscribers India is likely to have by 2015 predicted a report by Frost & Sullivan

5 Non-greasy palms, sirjee!

If there's one thing we all know India needs to reduce, it's the level of corruption. No one's really proved the whole 1.5 trillion USD lying in Swiss accounts theory, but it's not such a hard to believe number, given all the corruption you see on a daily basis.

Solution: Me-Mo

We could take a more serious look at the mobile-payment solutions already on offer, and make it easier for them to function. With enough government support, we could create a system where we all are easily identified as ourselves, and can securely pay using a variety of techniques, the most common of which would be a mobile phone. So that's a technology that knows who you are, wherever you are. Or more simply, knows Me when I'm Mobile (Me-Mo).

The idea here would be to do away paper money as much as possible, and especially notes above the Rs. 100 denomination. What would be needed is Cumulo-Indus, a mandatory registration of a biometric identity at census time and mandatory zero-balance bank accounts for everyone.

How it could work

The technology around today requires you to remember six or eight digit passwords, a mobile net connection, a smart phone and the ability to read English, no guesses for why the technology's not really catching on.

Apart from being constantly worried about our phones getting stolen, people in India just aren't used to transacting with anything but paper money. Although it might take years for a biometric census to complete, for once we'd like to see a government take the lead in planning for future events that could occur beyond its own term of power. This basically means that we should start now, and make it a mandatory affair.

The ordinary

The Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) has started on this path, even using biometric data! They call their project

Aadhaar, and the plan is to get a mix of PINs and biometrics, and log demographic data. If you've been counted, you'll get an Aadhaar number (like a social security number in the US), and have your fingerprint and iris impression stored.

With fingerprint readers becoming a common sight, it's not hard to imagine your fingers and eye impressions replacing your credit cards, if not all cash transactions.

The extraordinary

Replacing most, if not all, cash transactions is where the real attraction to this technology lies. Without large amounts of cash on people, or the ability to access them, the corruption rate ought to fall automatically. The amount of black money and fake currency schemes should also be reduced. However before this happens, we'll need the right infrastructure, a secure way of transacting and Cumulo-Indus access. With basic cameras being built into almost every mobile, face recognition, or iris impressions might not be that hard to authenticate.

Imagine you're at a local store and want to purchase something worth Rs. 412. All you'd have to do was click on "Pay" (in whatever was your preferred language), hold the phone's camera to the shopkeeper's eye, until he was recognised. Then you'd enter the amount – Rs. 412 – and hold the phone to your eye when asked to (again in your chosen language), and once authenticated, the amount would be transferred. Both you and the shopkeeper would get a confirmation SMS, and you'd walk out with your goods.

Why not just SMS payments like in the popular advertisement, as suggested by sirjee? Because it's not secure.

Of course there could more stringent methods for authentication for higher amounts, say, above Rs. 1,000. The RBI guidelines and rules would have to be changed though – currently mobile payments cannot cross Rs. 5,000 for funds transfers and Rs. 10,000 for purchases. Wide-spread adaptation of Me-Mo could force that though...

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